

BITE PRE-BUDGET ROUND TABLE (L-R) Ranade, Hiranandani, Joshi, Kumar, Badala and Sabnavis in Mumbai, Jan. 14

BITE

REVVING UP THE GROWTH ENGINE

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman will have a tough task ahead of her as she rises to present the Union budget for 2023-24 on February 1. Geopolitical uncertainties thrown up by the Ukraine war threaten to push one-third of the globe into recession, which will have a bearing on India's exports. COVID-19 still lurks in the background, and could force the Indian authorities to step up vigilance should it reappear. Meanwhile, a widening trade deficit, weakening exports and unemployment remain big sources of worry, even as core inflation remains stubbornly high. Boosting consumption, especially in rural areas devastated by climate catastrophes, as well as private investment continues to be a challenge. The **Board of India Today Experts** (**BITE**)—**Ajit Ranade**, Vice-chancellor, Gokhale Institute of Politics and Economics, Pune; **Niranjan Hiranandani**, Co-founder and MD, Hiranandani Group; **D.K. Joshi**, Chief Economist, Crisil; **Vivek Kumar**, Economist, QuantEco Research; **Sunil Badala**, Partner and National Head, BFSI Tax, KPMG; and **Madan Sabnavis**, Chief Economist, Bank of Baroda—met at The St. Regis Mumbai on January 14 to deliberate on the key issues before the country and how the FM could address them in the Budget. Edited excerpts:

Photographs by MILIND SHELTE